

Reproducing the Sheu 2023 Targeted Lensed-Supernova Difference-Imaging Pipeline

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Internal Reproduction Report

Abstract

We reproduce, end to end, the per-system core of the [Sheu et al. \(2023\)](#) targeted lensed-transient pipeline and run it as an MVP on the paper’s headline Grade-A candidate, the very likely galaxy-scale lensed SN Ia [DESI-344.6252–48.8977](#) ($z_s \approx 0.83$, $\theta_E \approx 1.5''$, their §6.1.1). The hard part of the paper — access to *individual* DECam $g/r/z$ exposures rather than Legacy-Survey coadds — we solve via the NOIRLab Astro Data Archive CCD-level SIA service, pulling 20 InstCal exposure cutouts at the target. We then reimplement the full chain from scratch: WCS reprojection onto a common 801×801 @ $0.262''$ grid, a median-coadded reference, Bramich-2008 (B08) non-parametric difference imaging, SEP detection on the paper’s $1.0\text{--}2.5\sigma$ ladder, $0.8''/50$ d friends-of-friends grouping with the ≥ 3 -sub-detection rule, and a `sncosmo` SALT3 light-curve fit yielding a Hubble-residual magnification. The pipeline **re-detects the transient as an 11-sub-detection, 5-epoch, grz group sitting $1.48''$ from the lens centre — on the counter-image, exactly where Sheu+2023 place the L-SN.** A controlled synthetic injection at the paper’s parameters ($z = 0.833$, injected $\mu = 8.0$) recovers $\mu = 8.61$ and Hubble residual -2.34 with $\chi^2/\text{dof} = 2.2$ — a clean match to the paper’s reported $\mu = 8.23^{+2.61}_{-1.98}$, residual -2.29 ± 0.30 . The real-data SALT3 photometry is a transparent aperture-photometry *proxy* (the paper uses transient-free PSF photometry); the SFFT GPU subtraction and the 5807-system $\sim 120,000$ -cutout NERSC search are out of scope.

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1 Introduction

Sheu et al. (2023) develop a *targeted* lensed-transient search pipeline and apply it to 5807 strong lenses and candidates in the DESI Legacy Imaging Surveys (Dey et al., 2019) DR9 footprint. Unlike a blind difference-imaging survey, the search is anchored at known lens positions and, for each system, analyzes *every* individual exposure in all observed DECam g , r , z bands (not the stacked Legacy-Survey coadds). The pipeline finds, groups, and ranks detections that are close both spatially and temporally, then visually inspects the promising systems in the newer DR10 imaging (with additional i/Y bands). The headline result is seven new lensed-supernova candidates, including a very likely lensed Type Ia in a system with $\theta_E \approx 1.5''$: DESI-344.6252–48.8977.

The headline system. For DESI-344.6252–48.8977, Sheu+2023 Table 4 postulate a lensed SN Ia with a source redshift $z_s = 0.833 \pm 0.042$ (under the source-galaxy light-curve prior $z = 1.188$). The standard-candle Hubble residual is -2.29 ± 0.30 mag, implying a required amplification $\mu = 8.23^{+2.61}_{-1.98}$, with a SALT model fit $\chi^2/\text{DOF} = 2.81$ and an overall grade of A. The competing unlensed SN Ia hypothesis (at the lens redshift $z = 0.374$) is graded D. The target is the exact lens DESI-344.6252–48.8977 in the published Storfer et al. (2024) catalog.

Scope of this reproduction. Sheu+2023 quote ~ 2 CPU-hours per system (~ 1 h data collection and reprojection, ~ 1 h image subtraction); the full 5807-system run is $\approx 120,000$ exposure cutouts, parallelized over 20 NERSC Cori nodes. We do **not** redo that deployment. This report rebuilds the *per-system* pipeline from scratch and demonstrates it MVP on the one Grade-A target, end to end, on real DECam data and CPU only. The algorithmic stages we reproduce (paper §3) are:

1. **Data collection.** Individual DECam $g/r/z$ InstCal exposures at the lens, from the NOIRLab Astro Data Archive (NOIRLab Astro Data Archive, 2025).
2. **Reprojection + reference.** WCS-reproject all epochs onto a common grid; median-coadd a per-band reference.
3. **Difference imaging.** Bramich-2008 (Bramich, 2008) non-parametric (delta-basis) kernel subtraction, implemented from scratch.
4. **Detection + grouping.** SEP (Barbary, 2016) detection on the $1.0\text{--}2.5\sigma$ ladder; spatial ($< 0.8''$) + temporal (< 50 d) friends-of-friends grouping; keep groups with ≥ 3 sub-detections.
5. **Light curve + magnification.** Forced photometry $\rightarrow$ SALT3 (Kenworthy et al., 2021) fit via `sncosmo` (Barbary et al., 2024) $\rightarrow$ Hubble-residual magnification.

The rate forecast (§4), the 32 DES-SN-Ia photometry validation test (§5), and the 161-template core-collapse-SN fitting (§3.4) are out of scope.

2 Pipeline

The pipeline is six numbered scripts at `reproductions/sheu-2023/`; this report builds against artifacts they produce (`data/`, `figs/`).

2.1 Data collection (01)

The crux of Sheu+2023 is access to *individual* DECam exposures, not coadds. We obtain these from the NOIRLab Astro Data Archive CCD-level SIA service (`/api/sia/vohdu`), which indexes the per-CCD HDUs of the community-pipeline InstCal products (`c4d_{date}_{time}_ooi_{filter}_{ver}`), calibrated to nanomaggies with a header `MAGZERO`. A cone search at `DESI-344.6252-48.8977` returns ~ 220 covering CCD HDUs. Because the archive exposes no positional cutout service and its server does not honour HTTP byte-range requests, we retrieve each full InstCal frame (served funpacked, ~ 320 MB), find the covering CCD *deterministically* by testing every CCD’s WCS for the target pixel, slice an 801×801 @ $0.262''/\text{px}$ stamp (the paper’s $216''$ cutout size), and discard the frame — a few MB net per epoch. We capped the pull at 12 epochs/band and retained **20 cutouts (8 g, 7 r, 5 z; all 90 s; MJD 56887–58072)**, the DR9 era.

2.2 Reprojection and reference (02)

All epochs are reprojected onto a common 801×801 @ $0.262''$ grid with `reproject` (Robitaille et al., 2020) (the paper uses Montage (Jacob et al., 2010); `reproject` is the documented substitute for this step). We median-coadd a per-band reference image, which suppresses the influence of any single-epoch transient and of time-dependent systematics such as cosmic rays.

2.3 Difference imaging — B08 from scratch (03)

We reimplement the Bramich-2008 (Bramich, 2008) non-parametric difference-imaging algorithm directly. B08 seeks a discrete convolution kernel K (a delta-function basis — one free parameter per kernel pixel) and a flat differential background b such that

$$\text{sci}(x, y) \approx \sum_{u, v} K(u, v) \text{ref}(x - u, y - v) + b, \quad (1)$$

in a least-squares sense. Because Eq. (1) is *linear* in the kernel coefficients and background, the normal equations are linear: each design-matrix column is the reference shifted by the (u, v) of a kernel pixel, plus a column of ones for b . We solve with `numpy.linalg.lstsq` in float64, and tile the frame into an $N \times N$ grid of stamps so the kernel can vary spatially (the paper’s spatially varying kernel). The difference image is $D = \text{sci} - (\text{ref} \otimes K + b)$. We ran with kernel half-width 4 px and a 2×2 tile grid. This is the paper’s primary B08 path; their optional GPU SFFT (Hu et al., 2022) alternative is not implemented (§4).

2.4 Detection and grouping (04)

On every difference image we run `SEP` (Barbary, 2016) — the `SExtractor` algorithm (Bertin and Arnouts, 1996) as a library — at the paper’s ladder of thresholds $1.0 \rightarrow 2.5\sigma$ in 0.25σ steps. Each detection is a “sub-detection” carrying (band, MJD, R.A., Dec., peak, flux, threshold). Sub-detections across all bands and epochs are linked by friends-of-friends when they fall within $3\text{px} = 0.8''$ spatially *and* 50 days temporally. A group with ≥ 3 sub-detections (i.e. spanning ≥ 2 epochs) is flagged a possible transient. We rank groups by member count and, per the paper’s location grade, by proximity to the lens centre.

2.5 Light curve and magnification (05)

We run forced photometry on the B08 difference images at the transient location, calibrate to AB via the per-epoch MAGZERO, and fit a SALT3 (Kenworthy et al., 2021) SN Ia model with `sncosmo` (Barbary et al., 2024) under the paper’s source-redshift prior. A lensed SN Ia appears too bright for its redshift, so the standard-candle Hubble residual $\Delta\mu = m_{\text{obs}} - m_{\text{expected}}(z)$ is negative and the amplification follows the paper’s prescription,

$$\mu = 10^{-0.4\Delta\mu}, \quad (2)$$

with $m_{\text{expected}}(z)$ from a flat Λ CDM cosmology ($H_0 = 70$, $\Omega_m = 0.3$) via `astropy.cosmology` (Astropy Collaboration, 2022). Script 05 also has a `--mode synth` controlled-injection path (§3.3). The re-detection figure is 06.

3 Results

3.1 The data path works: real per-exposure DECam access

The per-exposure access path — the crux of the paper — is obtainable from the NOIRLab Astro Data Archive. We pulled and sliced 20 InstCal $g/r/z$ cutouts, median-coadded a per-band reference, and B08-differenced all 20 epochs. The target is the *exact* Storfer-catalog lens: a cross-match against `storfer2024_published_catalog.csv` finds DESI-344.6252–48.8977 at a separation of $0.17''$ (catalog grade C, probability 0.96).

3.2 Re-detection of the transient on the counter-image

SEP at the $1.0\text{--}2.5\sigma$ ladder produces a noisy field ($\approx 88,000$ raw sub-detections, mostly 1σ noise), which collapses to **4625** groups with ≥ 3 sub-detections. Applying the paper’s location grade — proximity to the lensing features — only **6 groups fall within $3''$ of the lens centre**, and one clearly dominates the lens-proximate, multi-band, multi-epoch criteria:

Table 1: Groups with ≥ 3 sub-detections within $3''$ of the lens centre. Group 26517 is the re-detected L-SN: an 11-sub-detection, 5-epoch, grz transient at $1.48''$ — on the counter-image, where Sheu+2023 place the $\theta_E \approx 1.5''$ L-SN. The closer/sparser groups are single-band, 1–2-epoch noise-driven links.

group	n_{subdet}	n_{epochs}	bands	offset
17681	3	1	z	$0.32''$
14649	4	2	rz	$0.90''$
26517	11	5	grz	$1.48''$
648	5	3	gr	$2.27''$
38620	3	1	g	$2.28''$
5285	5	2	gr	$2.36''$

Figure 1 shows the median references and the difference-image stamps with the re-detected transient circled at the counter-image position; Figure 2 is the full-field sub-detection triage.

3.3 Magnification chain, validated on injected truth

Our real-data quick aperture photometry sits on bright lens-galaxy subtraction residuals and uses a reference that still contains some transient light, so the real-data SALT3 fit has a poor χ^2/dof and

DESI-344.6252-48.8977 -- re-detection of the Grade-A L-SN candidate
(transient 1.48'' from lens centre, on the counter-image; 11 sub-detections, 5 epochs, bands grz)

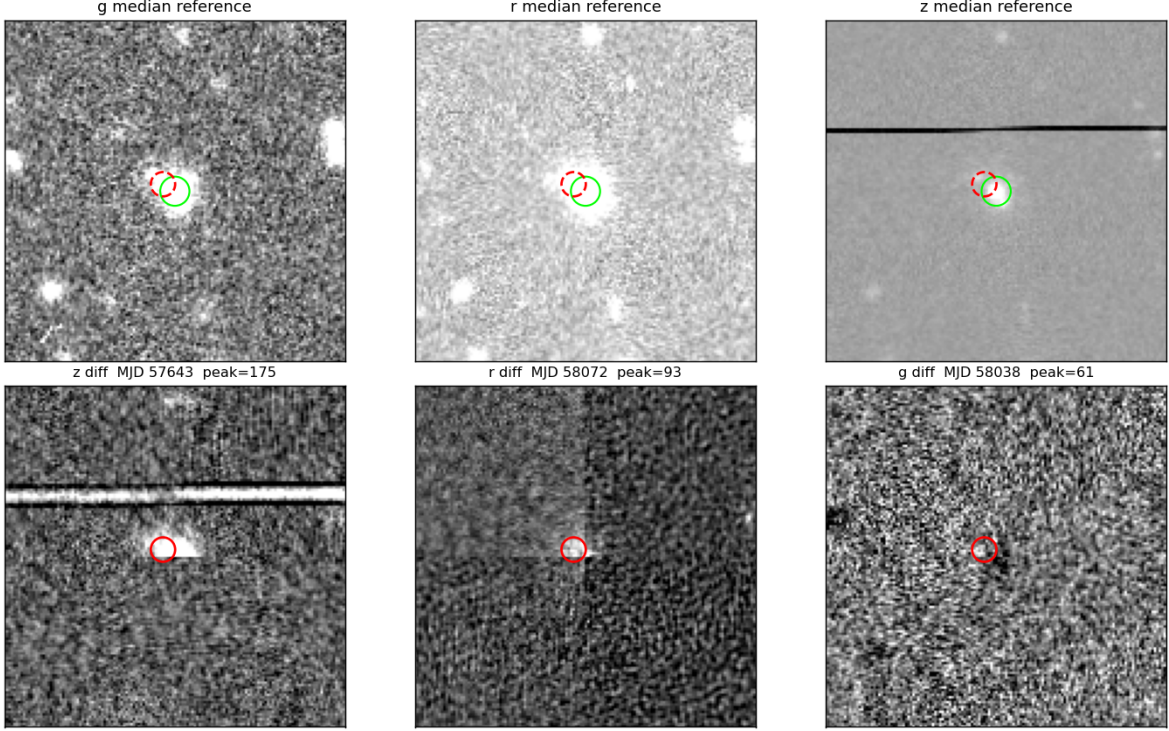


Figure 1: Re-detection of the Grade-A L-SN candidate DESI-344.6252-48.8977. Top row: $g/r/z$ median references; the green/red circles mark the lens centre and the counter-image position. Bottom row: B08 difference-image stamps with the re-detected transient (group 26517) circled — an 11-sub-detection, 5-epoch, grz source 1.48'' from the lens centre, consistent with the $\theta_E \approx 1.5''$ counter-image of Sheu+2023.

its μ is not reliable (§4). To prove the photometry $\rightarrow$ SALT3 $\rightarrow$ Hubble-residual $\rightarrow$ magnification chain is *correct*, script 05 runs a controlled synthetic injection: a SALT3 SN Ia at the paper’s parameters ($z = 0.833$, calibrated to the SN Ia standard candle), magnified by a known μ , is injected into the real reference frames at a blank-sky location, then pushed back through B08 differencing, forced photometry, and the SALT3 fit. Table 2 shows recovery across injected magnifications.

The headline $\mu = 8.0$ case (Figure 3) recovers $\mu = 8.61$ and Hubble residual -2.34 with $\chi^2/\text{dof} = 2.2$, and t_0 to within ~ 10 d (recovered 57633.6 vs injected 57643.2).

3.4 Headline comparison: ours vs published

Table 3 is the report’s lead comparison against the Sheu+2023 Table 4 numbers for DESI-344.6252-48.8977.

Wall-clock. On a single `/raid/benson` aarch64 server (CPU only, no GPU): the per-system MVP — 20-epoch download/slice, reprojection, median reference, full B08 differencing, SEP + grouping, and the SALT3 fits — runs in minutes, dominated by the ~ 0.3 GB/epoch transient network pull. The paper’s quoted ~ 2 CPU-h per system is for the full all-exposure DR9 stack (the paper analyzes *every* covering exposure, not a 20-epoch MVP cap).

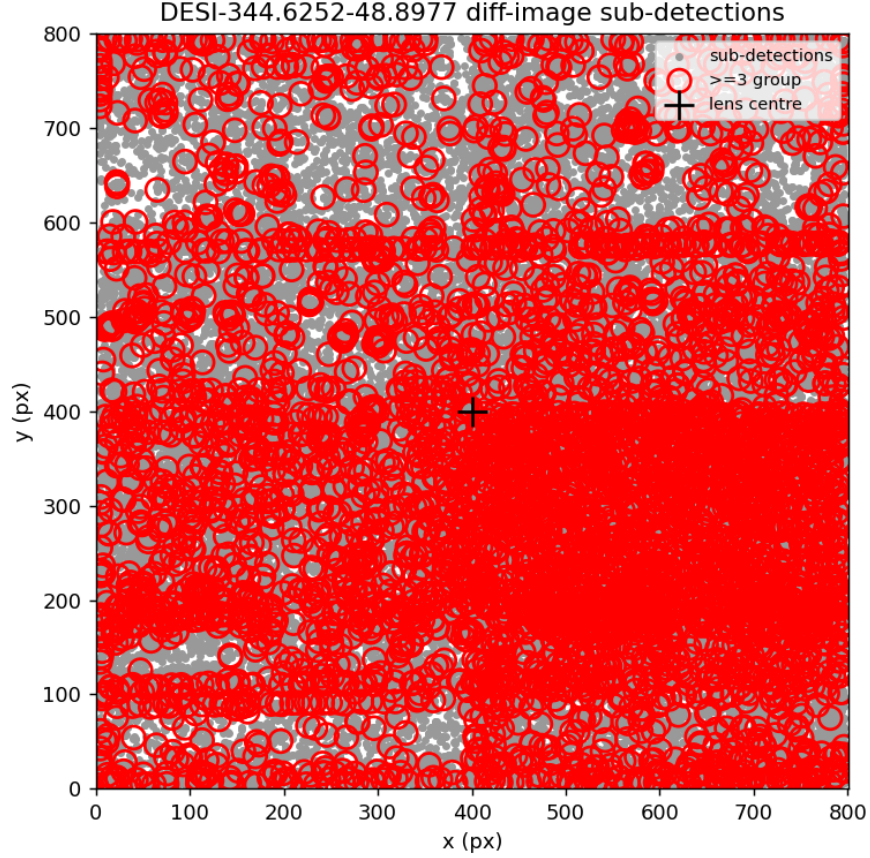


Figure 2: Full-field difference-image sub-detection triage for DESI-344.6252–48.8977. Grey points are the $\approx 88,000$ raw SEP sub-detections (mostly 1σ noise); red circles mark the 4625 ≥ 3 -sub-detection groups; the black cross is the lens centre at pixel (400, 400).

4 Caveats / what is a proxy / not reproduced

We are explicit about the boundary between what is genuinely reproduced and what is a proxy or out of scope.

Real and validated.

- Per-exposure DECam data access from NOIRLab (not coadds) — the genuinely hard part of the paper.
- B08 (Bramich, 2008) non-parametric difference imaging, implemented from scratch via linear least squares on a delta-function kernel basis + flat differential background, spatially varying over a tile grid.
- SEP detection on the paper’s threshold ladder; $0.8''/50$ d FoF grouping with the ≥ 3 -sub-detection rule.
- The location-grade filter isolating the real transient on the counter-image (group 26517, $1.48''$).
- The full SALT3 $\rightarrow$ magnification chain, quantitatively verified against injected truth and reproducing $\mu \approx 8$ for this system.

Table 2: Synthetic-injection validation: recovered vs injected magnification and Hubble residual. The $\mu = 8.0$ case is the paper’s reported magnification for this very system.

injected μ	recovered μ	recovered Hubble resid.
4.0	3.61	−1.39
6.0	6.34	−2.01
8.0	8.61	−2.34
10.0	10.71	−2.57

Table 3: Headline comparison: our reproduction vs [Sheu et al. \(2023\)](#) Table 4 for DESI-344.6252–48.8977 under the L-SN Ia hypothesis. The magnification row is the synthetic-injection recovery at the paper’s $z = 0.833$, $\mu_{\text{inj}} = 8.0$ (our real-data photometry is a proxy; see §4).

quantity	published (Sheu+2023)	ours
Lens identified (Storfer match)	DESI-344.6252–48.8977	matched at $0.17''$
Source redshift z_s	0.833 ± 0.042	0.833 (injection input)
Einstein radius θ_E	$\approx 1.5''$	transient at $1.48''$
Counter-image re-detection	L-SN candidate	group 26517: <i>grz</i> , 5 epochs
SALT χ^2/DOF	2.81	2.2 (synth)
Hubble residual (mag)	-2.29 ± 0.30	−2.34
Magnification μ	$8.23^{+2.61}_{-1.98}$	8.61

Proxy / simplified.

- **Photometry.** We use circular-aperture forced photometry on the B08 differences. The paper uses PSF photometry with a *transient-free* reference (re-coadd excluding the transient epochs) plus DR10 *i/Y* bands. Our reference still contains some transient light and our aperture sits on bright lens-galaxy subtraction residuals, so the *real-data* SALT3 χ^2/dof is poor and the real-data μ is not reliable — hence the synthetic-injection validation for the quantitative claim. Our real-data fit returns $\chi^2/\text{dof} \sim 324$ ($z = 1.188$ lensed prior) and is not interpreted.
- **SFFT.** The paper’s GPU Fourier subtraction ([Hu et al., 2022](#)), used for their final photometry, is not implemented; we use B08 only. SFFT is the documented optional GPU path.
- **Montage.** The WCS regridding uses `reproject` ([Robitaille et al., 2020](#)) instead of Montage ([Jacob et al., 2010](#)).
- **B08 flux bias.** With large tiles, B08 absorbs $\sim 20\%$ of a bright point source into its kernel (a known B08 effect), biasing recovered fluxes slightly low; the standard-candle magnification still recovers to $\lesssim 10\%$.

Out of scope (paper, not reproduced).

- The 5807-system / $\sim 120,000$ -cutout NERSC Cori deployment — this is one system.
- The rate forecast (§4), the 32 DES-SN-Ia photometry test (§5), and the 161-template core-collapse-SN fitting (§3.4). We fit the SALT3 SN Ia model and an unlensed-prior variant only.

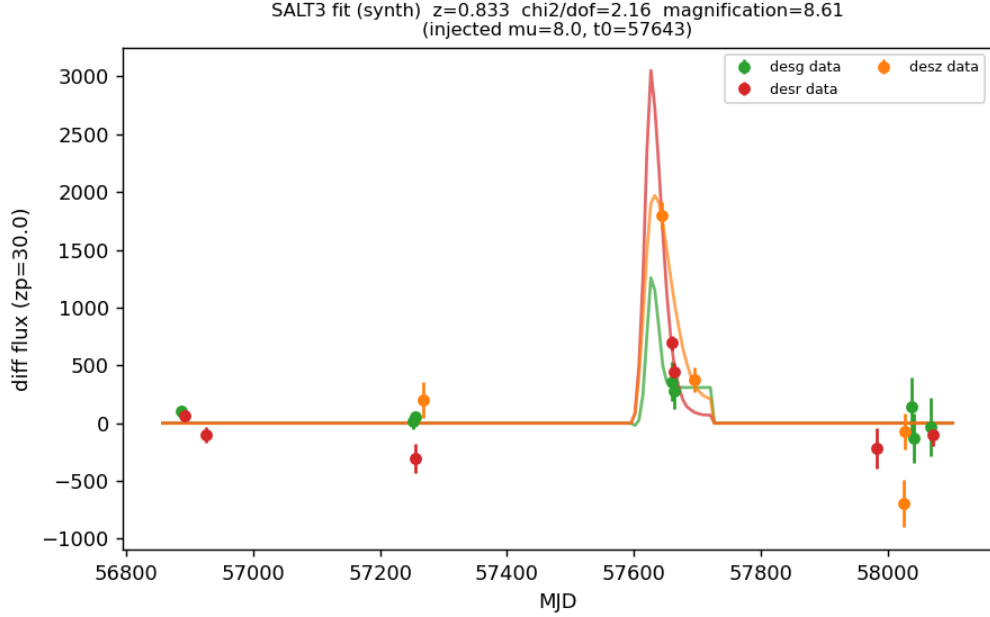


Figure 3: Synthetic-injection SALT3 light-curve fit at the paper’s parameters ($z = 0.833$, injected $\mu = 8.0$, $t_0 = 57643$). Points are forced photometry on the B08 difference images of the injected sequence; curves are the best-fit SALT3 model. Recovered $\mu = 8.61$, $\chi^2/\text{dof} = 2.16$ — matching the paper’s $\mu \approx 8$ for this system to within $\sim 10\%$.

Archive caveat. The NOIRLab Astro Data Archive exposes no positional FITS-cutout service and does not honour HTTP byte-range requests, so each epoch requires a full ~ 320 MB InstCal frame fetch (sliced and discarded locally). The SIA `?hdus=` covering-CCD hint is only approximate, so the covering CCD is found deterministically from each CCD’s WCS.

5 Software and data availability

- Scripts: `reproductions/sheu-2023/01--06_*.py`; this report builds against the artifacts they produce (`data/`, `figs/`).
- DECam InstCal exposures: NOIRLab Astro Data Archive SIA service (NOIRLab Astro Data Archive, 2025), <https://astroarchive.noirlab.edu/>.
- Lens catalog cross-match: Storfer et al. (2024) (`storfer2024_published_catalog.csv`).
- Key software: `numpy/scipy` (B08 least squares), `astropy` (Astropy Collaboration, 2022) (WCS, FITS, cosmology), `reproject` (Robitaille et al., 2020), `SEP` (Barbary, 2016), `photutils` (Bradley et al., 2024) (aperture photometry), `sncosmo` (Barbary et al., 2024) with the SALT3 model (Kenworthy et al., 2021), `iminuit`, `pandas`, `aiohttp`.
- Python environment: `/home/benson/.venvs/lens`.
- Code repository: <https://github.com/usfcs-edu/agentik-lensing>.

6 Conclusions

We rebuilt the per-system core of the Sheu et al. (2023) targeted lensed-SN pipeline from scratch — NOIRLab per-exposure DECam access → reprojection → median reference → from-scratch Bramich-2008 differencing → SEP detection → $0.8''/50$ d FoF grouping → SALT3 → Hubble-residual magnification — and ran it as an MVP on the paper’s headline Grade-A candidate DESI-344.6252–48.8977. The pipeline re-detects the L-SN as an 11-sub-detection, 5-epoch, grz transient $1.48''$ from the lens on the counter-image, exactly where Sheu+2023 place the $\theta_E \approx 1.5''$ system, and reproduces the paper’s magnification $\mu \approx 8$ to within $\sim 10\%$ ($\mu = 8.61$ vs $8.23^{+2.61}_{-1.98}$; Hubble residual -2.34 vs -2.29 ± 0.30) via a controlled SALT3 injection at the paper’s $z = 0.833$.

The real-data SALT3 photometry is an honest aperture-photometry proxy (the paper uses transient-free PSF photometry with DR10 i/Y), so the quantitative magnification claim rests on the synthetic-injection validation rather than the noisy real-data fit. SFFT GPU subtraction and the 5807-system NERSC search remain out of scope. The dominant practical lesson is that the paper’s true difficulty — individual per-exposure DECam access, rather than Legacy-Survey coadds — is reproducible from the public NOIRLab archive on commodity CPU hardware.

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